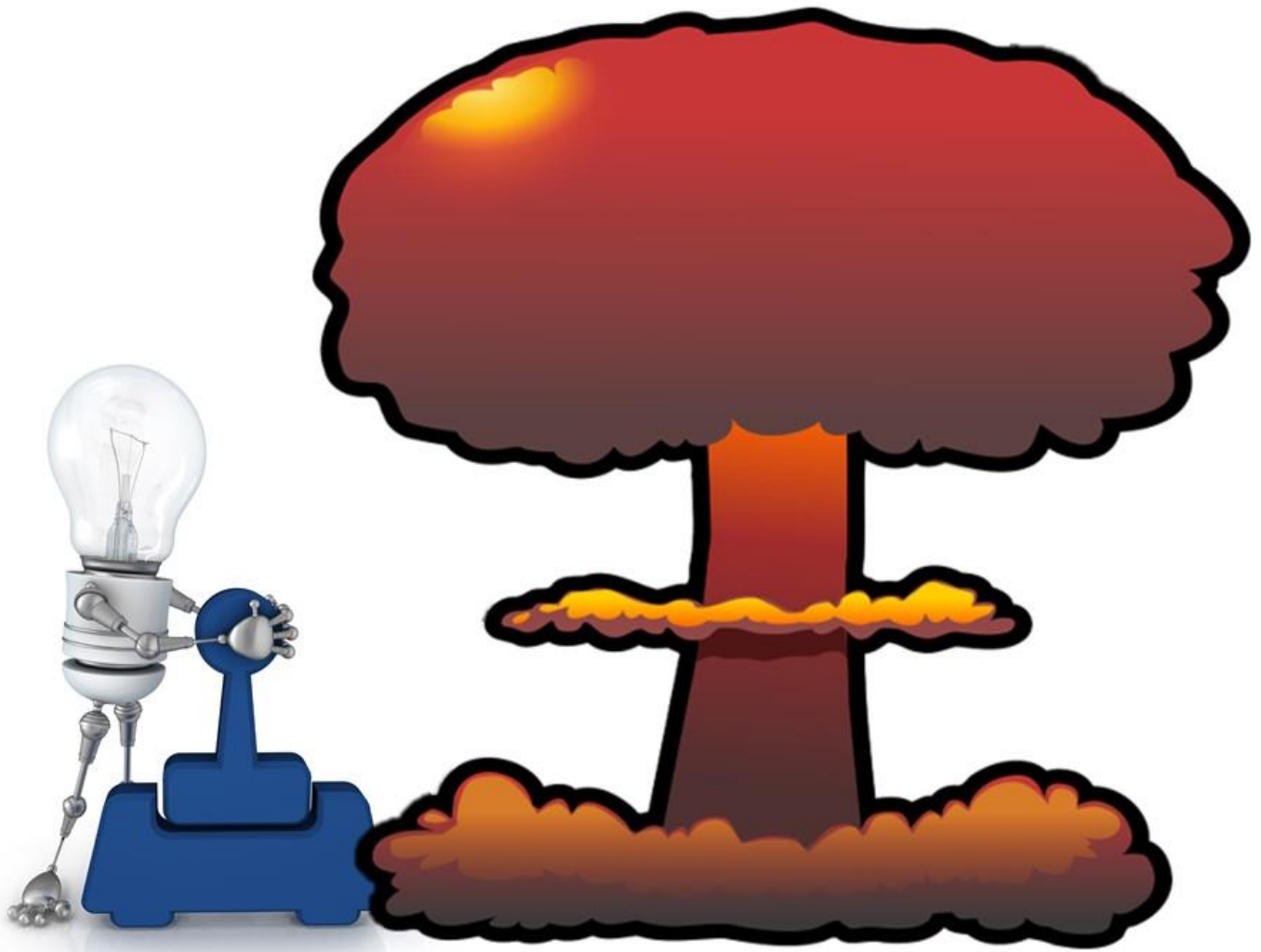




Exploring Conflict

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Conflict can occur through misunderstanding, miscommunication, differences of opinion, etc. Some level of disagreement will occur in even the healthiest of relationships from time to time as people see things from different perspectives. Resolving these differences amicably and to the satisfaction of all involved helps to generate new ways of working together and to build the relationship.

This exercise involves exploring the word *conflict* to gain insights into what the word means for a number of different people, so that you can get a variety of views and opinions.

Firstly, write down 4 words that come to mind when you think of the word *conflict*.

Ask a number of other people (about 4 or 5) to write down 4 words that come up for them when they think of the word *conflict*. They should not consult with others, just write down their own ideas. If they seem hesitant, point out that there are no *right or wrong* words, just their own ideas.

This will give you some interesting information and insights.

If it is possible, get everyone together to discuss and debate the list of words that you have collected. They must reduce the list down to 4 words that everyone can agree on.

This discussion about the word *conflict*, will enable them to bring their learning and insights through the discussion to create an even deeper exploration of the word. This will give everyone a much better understanding and agreement about what the word means for them personally, as a team member. They will, also, gain some agreement on the way they will work with conflict in the future.

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(This would work well at a team meeting, if you have consulted with every member of the team. It will help to raise the issue of conflict and help to agree some ground rules around working with conflict in a non-threatening, all-involving exercise. Different views and understanding that are associated with conflict can be teased out by the members of the team to create a more considerate and empathetic work environment.)

What observations have you made about the final words?

A large, empty rounded rectangle with a dark blue border, intended for writing observations.

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What new insights into conflict have you gained through the exercise?

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How did you feel about doing the exercise?

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What, if anything, have you learned from doing it?

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